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Edexcel GCSE Geography B (1GB0) — Component 1: Global Geographical Issues · Topic 2: Development Dynamics

1.4 Development Dynamics

1. Defining Development

Development refers to improvements in the standard of living and quality of life for people within a country. It is measured across two broad dimensions:

- **Economic development** — growth in wealth, industrialisation, trade, and GDP per capita.
- **Human development** — improvements in quality of life: health, education, wellbeing, and political freedom.

Development is best understood as a **continuum** — a sliding scale from the least to most developed — rather than a binary division of "developed" and "developing" worlds. Countries sit at different points on this continuum and move along it over time.

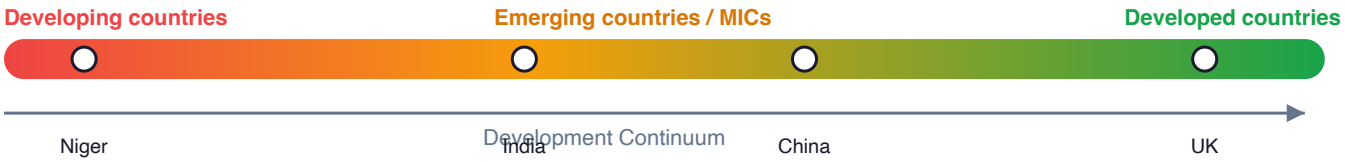
Classification of Countries

Developed countries (High Income Countries) — GNI per capita above ~$13,900 (World Bank threshold, 2025). Examples: USA, UK, Germany, Japan, Australia.

Developing countries (Low Income Countries) — GNI per capita below ~$1,135 (2025). Examples: Niger, South Sudan, DR Congo, Afghanistan.

Emerging countries (Newly Emerging Economies) — Countries rapidly industrialising and growing, often moving from developing status. Examples: China, India, Brazil, Nigeria, Mexico, Indonesia, Turkey, South Africa.

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Exam Tip: Avoid using the terms "first world / third world" or "developed / developing" in exam answers — they imply a binary and are outdated. Use developed country, developing country, emerging country, or "more/less economically developed country" (MEDC/LEDC). Examiners reward precise terminology.

2. Measuring Development

Development can be measured using **single indicators** (one measure) or **composite indicators** (combining multiple measures).

Single Indicators

Indicator	What It Measures	Advantage	Limitation
GNI per capita (US$)	Average wealth per person (Gross National Income / population)	Easy to compare internationally	Ignores inequality (distribution of wealth)
Birth rate (per 1,000)	Number of live births per 1,000 people per year	Indicates healthcare, education level	Affected by age structure of population
Death rate (per 1,000)	Number of deaths per 1,000 people per year	Reflects healthcare quality	Developed countries can have high death rates due to ageing population
Infant mortality rate (per 1,000)	Deaths of children under 1 year per 1,000 live births	Very sensitive indicator — falls quickly with development	May not reflect adult quality of life

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Life expectancy (years)	Average expected lifespan at birth	Reflects healthcare, nutrition, safety	Averages hide internal inequalities
Literacy rate (%)	% of adults who can read and write	Shows educational access	Doesn't measure quality of education
Access to clean water (%)	% of population with safe water supply	Directly linked to health outcomes	Data can be unreliable in developing countries
Calorie intake (per day)	Average daily calories consumed per person	Indicates food security and nutrition	Doesn't distinguish between nutritious/non-nutritious calories

Composite Indicator: Human Development Index (HDI)

HDI (Human Development Index) — developed by the UNDP, combines three dimensions into a score between 0 and 1:

1. **GNI per capita** (economic dimension)
2. **Life expectancy at birth** (health dimension)
3. **Mean years of schooling + expected years of schooling** (education dimension)

Country	HDI Score (2022)	Category	GNI per capita (PPP US$)	Life Expectancy
Norway	0.966	Very High	$82,500	83.2 years
UK	0.940	Very High	$45,225	81.3 years
China	0.788	High	$19,590	78.2 years
India	0.644	Medium	$7,420	67.7 years
Ghana	0.602	Medium	$5,269	64.1 years
Niger	0.394	Low	$1,284	62.4 years

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Advantages of HDI: more rounded than single indicators; recognises that development is multidimensional; widely used for international comparison.

Limitations of HDI: still doesn't capture inequality within countries; ignores environmental sustainability; ignores gender inequality, political freedom, happiness.

Exam Tip: The infant mortality rate is considered the most "sensitive" single indicator because it responds quickly to improvements in development (healthcare, sanitation, nutrition). Mention this in evaluation questions about measuring development.

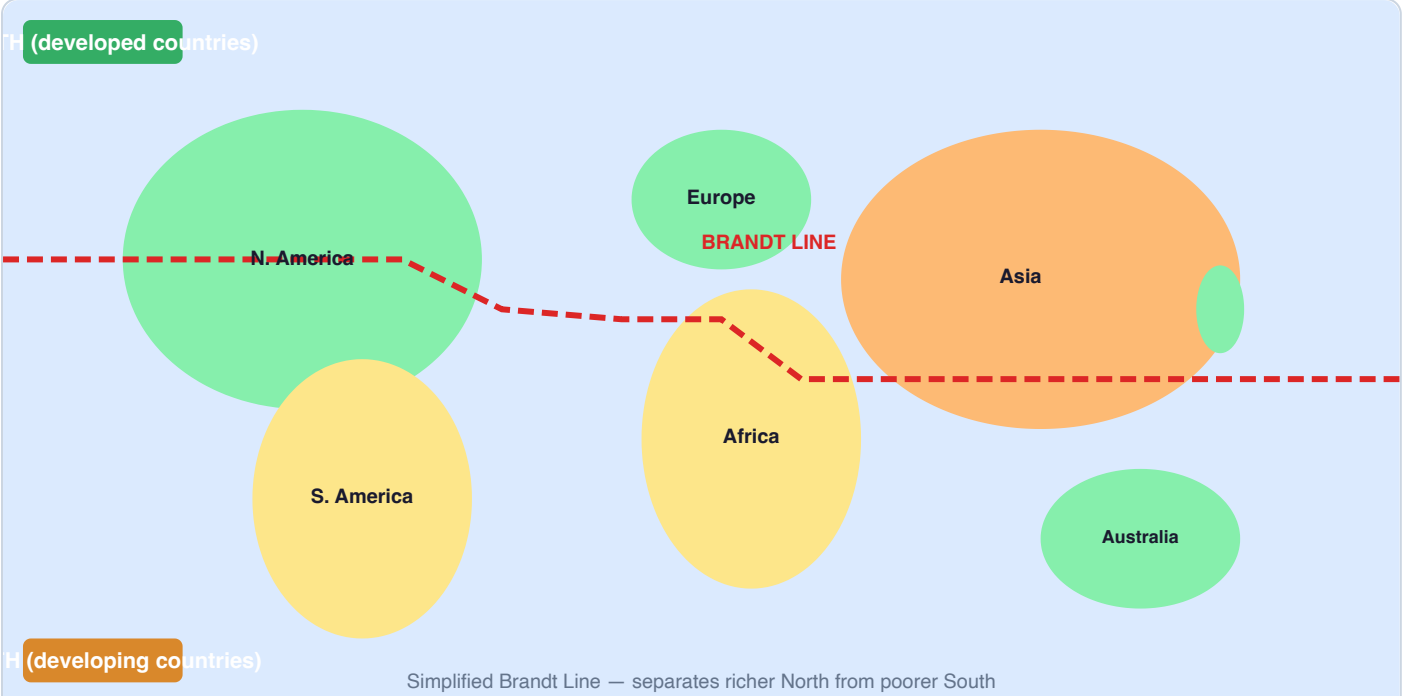
3. Other Measures of Development

Measure	What it shows
GDP per capita (PPP)	Average economic output per person, adjusted for purchasing power (what money buys locally).
Gini coefficient	How equally income is shared within a country, from 0 (perfect equality) to 1 (one person has everything). South Africa (~0.63) is one of the most unequal; Slovakia (~0.24) one of the most equal.
Gender inequality / female literacy	Shows how far women share in development — linked to lower birth rates and better child health.
Political corruption index	Transparency International's index shows perceived corruption, which can hold back development.

4. Patterns of Development

Wealth and development are unevenly distributed globally. A broad pattern is visible in the **North-South divide**, summarised by the **Brandt Line**.

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Simplified Brandt Line — separates richer North from poorer South

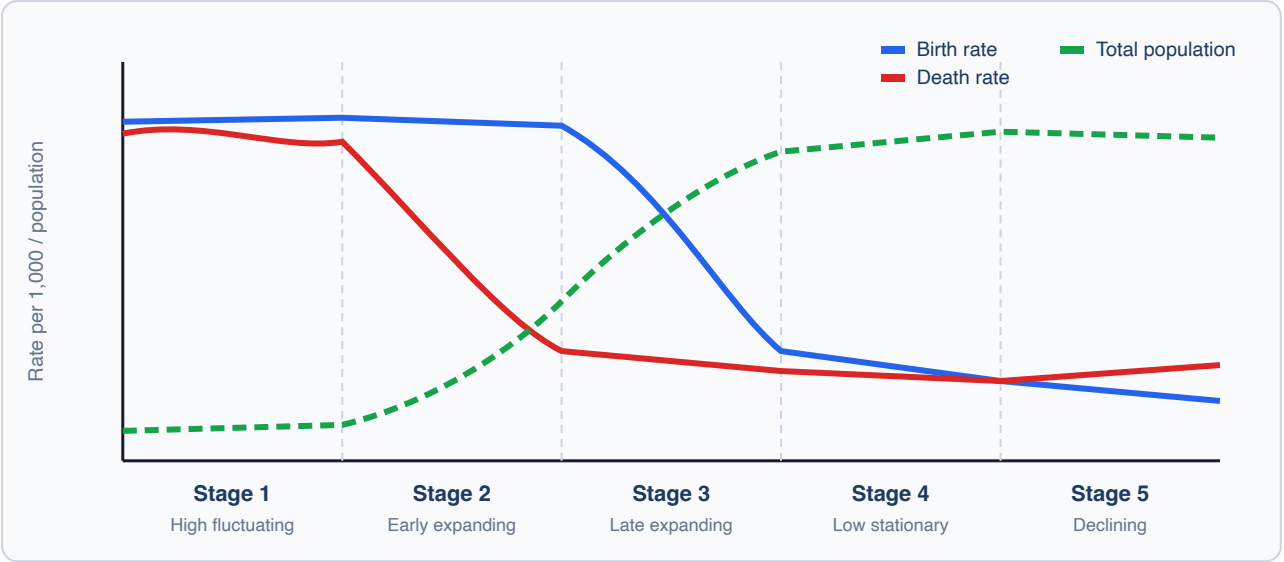
Key patterns of global wealth distribution:

- Developed countries are concentrated in North America, Western Europe, Japan, and Australia/NZ.
- Developing countries are concentrated in sub-Saharan Africa and parts of South/Southeast Asia.
- Sub-Saharan Africa has the highest concentration of the world's developing countries.
- Emerging countries — the BRICS (Brazil, Russia, India, China, South Africa) and MINT (Mexico, Indonesia, Nigeria, Turkey) — are rapidly changing the global economic landscape.
- The Brandt Line is a simplification: Australia and New Zealand are geographically south but economically "north".

> **Exam Tip:** The Brandt Line is a useful concept but always note its limitations — it oversimplifies a complex spectrum. Australia and NZ are exceptions. Many emerging countries are in the "south" but are growing rapidly.

5. The Demographic Transition Model (DTM)

The DTM shows how a country's **birth rate**, **death rate** and **total population** change over time as it develops.



Stage	Birth rate	Death rate	Population	Reasons	Example
1	High	High, fluctuating	Low, stable	No birth control; children needed for farm work; disease, famine and poor healthcare	A few remote tribes today
2	High	Falling rapidly	Rising rapidly	Improvements in healthcare, clean water, sanitation and food supply; birth rate stays high through tradition	Niger, Afghanistan
3	Falling rapidly	Falling more slowly	Rising more slowly	Contraception available; women educated and working; fewer children needed as infant mortality falls	India, Brazil, Nigeria (late stage 2/3)
4	Low	Low	High, stable	Family planning widespread; children expensive; good healthcare	UK, USA
5	Very low	Low, rising slightly	Slowly falling	Ageing population; people having children later or not at all	Japan, Italy, Germany

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Exam Tip: The DTM links directly to development — developing countries tend to be in stages 2–3, emerging countries in stage 3, and developed countries in stages 4–5. A limitation is that it is based on the experience of European countries and assumes all countries will follow the same path.

6. Causes of Uneven Development

Uneven development has multiple, interrelated causes — both physical and human.

Physical Causes

- **Landlocked countries** — no access to sea trade routes, making trade expensive (Mali, Chad, Zambia). 16 of the world's 32 landlocked developing countries are in Africa.
- **Tropical climate** — high temperatures and humidity increase prevalence of diseases (malaria, dengue) which reduce workforce productivity. Seasonal droughts reduce agricultural output.
- **Natural hazards** — frequent earthquakes, floods, cyclones destroy infrastructure and divert development funds to disaster relief (Haiti, Bangladesh).
- **Lack of natural resources** — limited mineral or energy wealth restricts income generation. However, the "resource curse" shows that over-reliance on a single resource (e.g. oil in Nigeria) can actually worsen inequality if wealth is poorly distributed.

Human Causes

- **Colonialism** — European powers extracted resources, cash crops, and labour from colonies for centuries. Infrastructure built to serve colonial export needs, not local development. Borders drawn arbitrarily, ignoring ethnic groups, causing post-independence conflict.
- **Trade inequality** — "Terms of trade" work against developing countries. Developing countries export primary commodities (cocoa, coffee, copper) at volatile, low prices; import manufactured goods at higher prices. "Commodity trap" — prices set by global markets, not producers.
- **Debt** — Many developing countries borrowed heavily in the 1970s-80s for development; interest repayments now exceed incoming aid. World Bank and IMF Structural Adjustment Programmes (SAPs) required cuts to health/education spending — worsening development.

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- **Political instability** — corruption diverts funds; civil war destroys infrastructure and displaces populations. South Sudan — world's youngest nation — suffered civil war from 2013 to 2018 and continuing instability since, preventing development. Conflict deters foreign investment.
- **Poor governance** — weak institutions, lack of rule of law, and corruption reduce effectiveness of development spending.

Exam Tip: "Explain why development is uneven" questions require you to state, explain, and link multiple causes. Don't just list them — explain the mechanism (e.g. "landlocked countries face higher transport costs, which makes imports more expensive and reduces trade, slowing economic growth").

7. Consequences of Uneven Development

Consequence	Detail
Disparities in wealth	The richest 10% of the world's population hold around three-quarters of global wealth. GNI per capita in the UK is over 40 times that of Malawi.
Disparities in health	Life expectancy is about 81 in the UK but under 55 in Nigeria and Chad. Infant mortality in Sierra Leone is roughly 20 times that of Japan. Lack of clean water and healthcare means diseases such as malaria and cholera remain common in developing countries.
International migration	People migrate from poorer to richer countries for jobs, higher wages and safety — economic migrants (e.g. from Eastern Europe to the UK) and refugees fleeing conflict. Remittances sent home can be a major source of income for developing countries.

8. Theories of Development

Rostow's modernisation theory (1960)

W. W. Rostow argued that all countries pass through **five stages of economic growth**:

1. **Traditional society** — mostly subsistence farming, little technology.
2. **Pre-conditions for take-off** — investment in infrastructure, education and commercial farming; some industry.
3. **Take-off** — rapid growth of manufacturing industries; investment from abroad.
4. **Drive to maturity** — economy diversifies; technology spreads; living standards rise.
5. **High mass consumption** — wealthy society with a large service sector and high consumer spending.

Criticisms: based on the experience of Europe and the USA; ignores colonialism and the unequal world trading system; assumes development is only economic growth.

Frank's dependency theory (1960s)

- André Gunder Frank argued that the world is divided into a wealthy **core** (developed countries) and a poor **periphery** (developing countries).
- The core keeps the periphery poor by buying its raw materials cheaply and selling manufactured goods back at high prices, and through debt and aid with conditions. Development in the core **depends on** underdevelopment in the periphery.
- **Criticisms:** it cannot explain how countries such as South Korea, Singapore and China have grown rapidly within the global economy.

> **Exam Tip:** Compare the theories: Rostow is optimistic (all countries can develop by following the same path); Frank is pessimistic (the global system prevents development). India and China support parts of both.

9. Globalisation and Development

Globalisation — the increasing interconnectedness of the world through trade, investment, migration, and communications.

Transnational Corporations (TNCs)

> **TNCs (Transnational Corporations)** — companies that operate in multiple countries. Examples: Nike, Apple, Shell, Unilever, Samsung. They locate headquarters in developed countries but

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manufacturing in developing and emerging countries to exploit lower labour costs, tax advantages, and weaker regulations.

Positive impacts on developing and emerging countries	Negative impacts on developing and emerging countries
Creates employment (often thousands of jobs)	Low wages — often close to minimum; poor working conditions
Technology transfer to local workers and firms	Profits repatriated back to developed country headquarters — "leakage"
Brings Foreign Direct Investment (FDI)	Environmental damage — weaker regulations exploited
Develops infrastructure (roads, ports)	Worker exploitation — long hours, unsafe conditions (Rana Plaza, Bangladesh 2013)
Increases exports and government tax revenue	Undermines local industries through competition

The Global Shift

Since the 1970s–80s, manufacturing has shifted from developed countries (USA, UK, Germany) to emerging countries and developing countries (China, Vietnam, Bangladesh, Mexico). This "global shift" has brought rapid industrialisation to Asia in particular, reducing absolute poverty for hundreds of millions of people. However, it has also led to deindustrialisation and job losses in traditional manufacturing regions of developed countries (e.g. Rust Belt, USA; steel towns in Wales/NE England).

Exam Tip: For TNC evaluation questions, structure your answer around: economic impacts (jobs, FDI, tax), social impacts (working conditions, urbanisation), and environmental impacts. Use a named TNC with specific details — Nike in Vietnam, or Apple's Foxconn factories in China — to access top marks.

10. Trade and Development

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International trade is a major driver of development — but access to trade and its terms are unequal.

Fairtrade

> **Fairtrade** — a trading partnership that ensures producers in developing countries receive a guaranteed minimum price for their goods, plus a "Fairtrade Premium" (extra money for community projects). Managed by the Fairtrade Foundation. Nearly 2 million farmers and workers in around 70 countries. Products include cocoa, coffee, bananas, cotton, gold.

- **Benefits:** stable income, social premium for schools/wells/healthcare, empowers smallholder farmers, encourages environmental standards.
- **Criticisms:** only a small fraction of the Fairtrade price reaches farmers; consumers pay more but benefit may be limited; not all large-scale producers can access Fairtrade certification.

Trade Blocs and the WTO

- **Trade blocs** (e.g. EU single market, NAFTA/USMCA) reduce tariffs between member countries — benefitting members but excluding developing countries.
- **WTO (World Trade Organisation)** — sets global trade rules. Accused of favouring developed country agendas; agricultural subsidies in the EU/USA undercut developing country farmers.

Commodity Dependence

- **Ghana** — heavily dependent on cocoa and gold exports. When cocoa prices fall, government revenue falls sharply.
- **Nigeria** — oil accounts for ~90% of export revenue and ~70% of government income. The "Dutch Disease": oil wealth causes the currency to rise, making other exports uncompetitive and damaging manufacturing.

11. Aid

Aid is the transfer of resources (money, goods, expertise) from one country or organisation to another, usually to help development or respond to a crisis.

Types of Aid

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Type	Description	Example
Bilateral aid	Government to government, often with political strings attached ("tied aid")	UK aid to Pakistan (FCDO)
Multilateral aid	Channelled through international organisations (UN, World Bank, IMF)	World Bank infrastructure loans
NGO aid	Non-governmental organisations funded by voluntary donations	Oxfam, Red Cross, WaterAid
Emergency/short-term aid	Rapid response to disasters — food, shelter, medicine	Nepal earthquake 2015 response
Long-term/development aid	Building infrastructure, improving education, strengthening institutions	WaterAid installing clean water systems

Tied Aid

> **Tied aid** — aid with conditions: recipient country must spend the money on goods/services from the donor country. Critics argue this benefits donor economies more than recipients.

Aid Debate

Arguments FOR aid	Arguments AGAINST aid
Saves lives in emergency situations	Can create dependency — countries rely on aid rather than developing own economies
Funds education and healthcare that governments cannot afford	Tied aid benefits donor country companies, not recipients
Builds essential infrastructure (roads, dams, schools)	Corruption diverts aid funds away from intended recipients

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Transfers technology and expertise	Inappropriate technology may not suit local conditions or skills
Helps rebuild after natural disasters	Aid can suppress local agricultural markets (food aid undercuts local farmers)

Exam Tip: When evaluating aid, use the phrase "sustainable development" — the most effective aid builds local capacity rather than creating dependency. Long-term development aid is generally considered more beneficial than emergency aid in the longer term.

12. Other Strategies to Reduce Inequality

Microfinance / Microcredit

Microfinance — small loans (micro-loans) given to individuals (often women) in developing countries to start or grow small businesses, without requiring collateral. Developed by the Grameen Bank in Bangladesh (founded 1983 by Muhammad Yunus). Over 9 million borrowers, 97% women. Average loan ~$200. Success rate high: ~98% repayment.

Benefits: empowers women, breaks poverty cycle, stimulates local economy, does not create national debt.
Criticisms: high interest rates in some schemes, small scale — cannot address systemic inequality.

Debt Relief

The **HIPC (Heavily Indebted Poor Countries) initiative** — IMF/World Bank programme that cancelled around $76 billion of debt for over 35 qualifying countries. Freed up government funds for health and education spending (Mozambique, Uganda, Bolivia). Conditions applied — some argue these conditions still favour creditor countries.

Intermediate/Appropriate Technology

Appropriate technology — technology that is suited to the local environment, skills, culture, and economic circumstances of the community. Often simple, low-cost, repairable locally. Championed

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by NGO Practical Action (formerly ITDG).

- Wind pumps for irrigation (Kenya) — no fuel needed, maintained locally.
- Solar cookers (India) — reduce firewood use, improve health (less indoor smoke).
- Biosand filters (Cambodia) — clean water at low cost.
- Treadle pumps (Bangladesh) — foot-powered irrigation for small farmers.

Tourism

Tourism brings foreign exchange to developing and emerging countries. **Kenya** — safari and beach tourism earns billions of dollars a year, creating jobs in rural areas. **Maldives** — ~28% of GDP from tourism. However: leakage (profits leaving to TNC-owned hotels in developed countries), environmental damage (reef degradation), seasonality of income, vulnerability to global events (COVID-19 devastated Maldives tourism).

Export Processing Zones (EPZs)

EPZs are designated areas where companies pay reduced taxes and have relaxed regulations to attract foreign investment and manufacturing. China used EPZs (Shenzhen Special Economic Zone from 1980) as a key driver of rapid industrialisation and export growth.

13. Top-Down and Bottom-Up Development

	Top-down	Bottom-up
Definition	Large-scale projects planned and funded by governments, international organisations or TNCs	Small-scale projects run by and for local communities, often supported by NGOs
Examples	Large dams (Sardar Sarovar, India), motorways, industrial zones	Microfinance, appropriate technology, community water projects, solar lamps

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Advantages	Can transform whole regions — electricity, irrigation, jobs; attract investment	Cheap, meets local needs, uses local skills, sustainable, communities have ownership
Disadvantages	Expensive; can create debt; local people may be displaced and benefits may go to cities and businesses	Small scale — limited impact on national development; relies on NGO funding

14. Case Study: India — An Emerging Country

India — location and context

- In South Asia, bordered by Pakistan, China, Nepal and Bangladesh, with coasts on the Arabian Sea and Bay of Bengal.
- The world's most populous country (about 1.45 billion people) and one of the fastest-growing major economies; the world's fifth-largest economy by GDP.
- Ruled by Britain until independence in 1947; a democratic republic. Economic reforms in **1991** opened the economy to foreign trade and investment.

Economic change and globalisation

- GDP has grown at around 6–8% a year for much of the period since the 1990s.
- The economic structure has shifted from agriculture towards services: agriculture employs about 45% of workers but produces under 20% of GDP; services produce over half of GDP.
- India is a global centre for **IT and business services** — Bengaluru ("India's Silicon Valley"), Hyderabad and Pune host firms such as Infosys, Tata Consultancy Services and Wipro, and offices of Google, Microsoft and Amazon.
- **TNCs** invest in India because of a large, young, English-speaking workforce, lower labour costs and a huge domestic market. Examples: Unilever (Hindustan Unilever), Apple suppliers making iPhones near Chennai, and car makers such as Suzuki and Hyundai.

Impacts of rapid development

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Positive	Negative
Hundreds of millions lifted out of extreme poverty; a growing middle class	Large regional disparities — states such as Kerala, Maharashtra and Tamil Nadu are much richer than Bihar and Uttar Pradesh
Life expectancy has risen to about 70; literacy over 75%	Inequality between rich and poor and between urban and rural areas
Improved infrastructure: highways, metro systems, airports, near-universal electrification of villages	Air pollution — Delhi is regularly among the world's most polluted cities; water pollution in the Ganges
Growing global influence (G20, space programme)	Rapid urbanisation and slums; pressure on water resources

Demographic and geopolitical change

- Birth rate and fertility have fallen (fertility is now about 2 children per woman), giving a large working-age population — a potential "demographic dividend".
- Geopolitically, India is a nuclear power, a leading member of the G20 and BRICS, and seeks a permanent seat on the UN Security Council.

Top-down vs bottom-up in India

- **Top-down — Sardar Sarovar Dam** on the Narmada River (Gujarat, completed 2017): provides irrigation water to millions of hectares, drinking water and hydroelectricity, but displaced tens of thousands of families and flooded farmland and forests; the Narmada Bachao Andolan protest movement campaigned against it for decades.
- **Bottom-up — Barefoot College** (Tilonia, Rajasthan): trains rural women, many of them illiterate, as "solar engineers" who install and maintain solar lighting in their villages; cheap, sustainable and empowering, but small-scale.
- **Bottom-up — self-help groups and microfinance:** millions of women's groups save and borrow together to start small businesses.

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Exam Tip: A common 8-mark question is "Assess the extent to which India's economic growth has benefited all of its people." Use regional disparity, urban–rural inequality and environmental costs to balance the evidence of rising incomes and falling poverty.

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